

SEVEN SISTERS · MARRA WONGA

Wattanuri, and the ones he followed.

The published record, and as much of the rest as is told away from Country.

At the southern end of the Marra Wonga shelter is an engraved figure the Iningai know as Wattanuri. Further along the wall, seven star-like markings sit apart from the rest of the engravings, set with care rather than scattered. They are the sisters he never caught.

The reading was published in 2022, the result of a study that began in September 2020, led by Professor Paul Taçon of Griffith University's rock art research unit, working directly with Iningai Traditional Owners. Suzanne Thompson is named as a co-author on the paper itself — not a source interviewed for it, a researcher credited on it.

Taçon has pointed out that it's rare anywhere in the world to have living testimony and formal archaeology aligned this closely. Marra Wonga is one of the few sites left where both still stand together, checked against each other rather than one replacing the other.

No other rock art site is known anywhere in the world with a narrative that runs across the entirety of the site.

Across Australia, figures like Wattanuri appear again and again in Seven Sisters stories as a Clever Man — someone who can shift shape, becoming a tree, an animal, sometimes a snake, in pursuit of the sisters. On the Marra Wonga wall, a long engraved snake runs north from where the stars end. It's read two ways: as Wattanuri himself, shifted into another form, or — in some contemporary Iningai readings — as the memory of a creature that no longer exists at all.

During fieldwork in 2020, researchers found an eighth star, hidden near the floor at the far end of the wall — not set to be seen from a distance like the other seven, but tucked into a corner, facing the wrong way. Some in the community read it as one of the sisters, still on Earth, hiding from Wattanuri. A dingo track sits just above it. Read together, it looks like the dingo is watching over her.

Stories like this one are held in at least eighty-three places across Australia, part of songlines that cross language groups and state borders. In 2017 the National Museum of Australia toured a major exhibition built around them. Marra Wonga's version isn't an isolated local story — it's one documented point on a much older, much larger map.

What the chase did along the way is said to have shaped Country still standing today, the same way it shaped the wall — not confined to the rock, but carried in the land itself.

IN ININGAI LAW

This sits underneath everything else told about Marra Wonga — not because it matters least, but because it is the oldest. Law isn't dated the way a study is dated. It is the floor everything else has been resting on the whole way down.

Some of what's on the wall is common knowledge. Some is women's, and some is men's. What's written here is only what is told away from Country — the rest is held by the people whose story it is.

Wattanuri is still there, at the southern end of the wall. So are the sisters — six of them in plain sight, and a seventh hidden, still watched over. Some stories don't need an ending written down. They need the wall left standing, and someone left to walk it in order, the way it's been walked for longer than the wall has ever been dated.

Taçon, Greenwood, Jalandoni, Thompson et al., "Marra Wonga: Archaeological and contemporary First Nations interpretations of one of central Queensland's largest rock art sites," *Australian Archaeology*, 2022.

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